

AR

magnum

BEAIDON

magnum is an agency, an archive, a quarrelsome family of photographers and, now that it has entered its sixth decade, a tradition. in the decisive moment that makes a photograph, instinct and tradition come together in the blink of a shutter. without instinct, no picture; without tradition, a picture which will not endure. some traditions fade and die, but this one – judging from this collection – is still alive. the old masters are present while the new masters are on show. they want to say: look at us now, look at what magnum has become.

george rodger. aftermath of v2 rocket. london, 1944 (courtesy life ©time inc.)



in order to understand what it has become, we have to understand what it was. no short answer is possible. there never was a single magnum style or subject. if one were to hazard a definition of the central commitment of magnum, it would be to document the world as it really is. but to document is to subvert, since reality is the least obvious thing there is. to approach it one has to strip away the clichés that keep it hidden from our sight. each of the photographers in this collection gives a different account of what reality is for them. but all seem to share an intense conviction that the world needs to be photographed if it is to be understood; that the

medium exists to make us look again, to see the world with fresh eyes, in all its astounding complexity. this is the red thread in the magnum story: the founders' commitment to the medium itself, to the belief that photography has a unique capacity to document reality, and in so doing to transform it into images that we are unable to forget.

this much has endured over the past fifty years. but magnum always had a politics as well. what has remained of that? the vision of the magnum founders was rooted in the liberal, anti-fascist opposition of the european left of the 1930s. for magnum, politics and photography were inseparable from the beginning. two of its founding fathers – robert capa and chim seymour – were jews escaping the anti-semitic atmosphere of budapest and warsaw in the early 1930s. when they reached paris, they aligned themselves with the left, but the populist, non-sectarian photojournals they worked for, such as 'vu', saved them from the dead hand of left aesthetics. capa's first published photo was of the renegade in exile, leon trotsky, giving a fiery address in copenhagen. seymour photographed the bitter parades of workers and war veterans through the streets of paris. these journalistic assignments did not allow them to be either precious or didactic. capa's ideal was to get as close as he dared and to keep it simple. yet nothing was as simple as it seemed. like ernest hemingway, who became a close friend, capa liked to pretend that he was just a danger-loving photojournalist. in fact, just like hemingway, he was a fastidious and complex artist. in the tradition he founded, journalistic and artistic impulses were twinned opposites. the impulse to get close to danger saved the photography from becoming formalistic, while capa's natural eye for composition rescued his images from journalism's clichés.

co-founder henri cartier-bresson, active in magnum today, came not from the hounded jewry of eastern europe, but from the wealthy commercial classes of france, and not from the hard school of photojournalism but from the world of surrealism. in cartier-bresson's hands, photography served the surrealist programme of subverting trust in the reality of the world. yet capa famously advised cartier-bresson that becoming a surrealist photographer was a trap. 'be a photojournalist. if not you will fall into mannerism.' magnum's founders thrived on the conflict between art and



journalism, the surreal and the real. magnum was never just a tradition of war photography or social realism: its best work was always both art and documentation, poetry and prose.

the first test of this new photojournalism came in the spanish civil war. it was the first war that 'vu' and 'life' and 'picture post' were able to cover with full-page spreads and narrative captions provided by the photographers. the photographers – capa especially – got so close that the editors and readers back home felt they could hear the explosions and smell the cordite. capa's photograph of a republican soldier in his white shirt leaping over a trench and dying with his rifle outstretched became a symbol both of a cause and of war's tragic glamour. and his famous image of the bilbao woman looking up into the sky, holding her daughter's hand, seemed to point the way towards the ominous, yet still unseen, future of war itself. as she looks up into the sky, we can see hamburg, dresden and hiroshima.

in world war II, george rodger, another of magnum's founders, was out in the ruins of london, making canonical images of the blitz, and later of the effects of the v2 rockets, such as the dust-covered woman on a stretcher being lifted out of her bombed-out house in london in 1944 (page 52). this is canonical because it is free of propagandistic intent, free of the ex-post-facto creation of the war on the home front as a glorious moment of british defiance and national solidarity. rodger's photograph, like all of magnum's great work, makes you think: yes, this is how it really is.

likewise, capa's picture of the landing on the normandy beaches (this page), with its juddery lack of focus, has an authenticity which 'saving private ryan' cannot equal, not least because we know that capa was there, waist-high in the bloody surf. but the picture also relies for its drama on seeing the landing not as a great victory in the making but as an equivocal moment which may end in disaster. magnum photographs have authority as documents because they capture the present at the instant in which it turns into history. they conserve their capacity to surprise because they are still unburdened by history's retrospective weight of meanings. photography enables us to see the past before the future has decided what it means. capa's photographs of the liberation of france – the shaved mother and her daughter hounded up the cobbled streets of a french town by a baying crowd in late 1944 – express the savagery which the euphoric memory of liberation wished to forget. they both document a moment in history and reach beyond it to express the timeless violence of all exercises in popular justice.

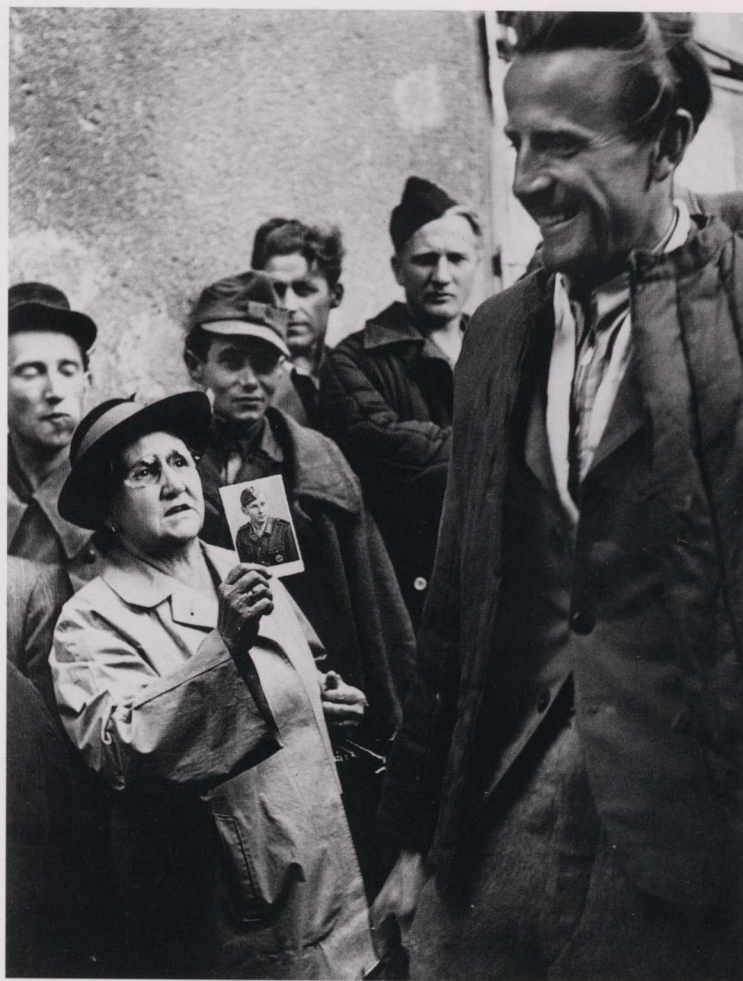
magnum grew out of what world war II did to the men and women who photographed it. george rodger, who had been through the blitz, north africa and the italian campaign, saw his war end at belsen in the spring of 1945. what he witnessed there made him give up war photography forever. recording evil seemed useless in the face of its enormity. magnum photographers have lived with this sense of helplessness ever since. erich lessing was so disillusioned by the west's sentimental indifference to the hungarian uprising and his photos of the freedom fighter's lime-covered corpse in front of the soviet tanks, that he gave up photojournalism altogether. james nachtwey has faced the same disillusion in rwanda; gilles peress in bosnia. history since 1945 has thrown up circumstances in which a photographer can only ask: what am i doing here? what is the point of taking pictures? but this very doubt – and the struggle to overcome it – has led to some of magnum's most memorable work. magnum's documentation of evil is a testament to the uses of despair. documentation of cruel obscenity always seems insufficient. but the essential audience for these pictures is the future. we who come after owe our belief in the reality of these abominations – our certainty that they existed – to the photographs that rodger took. just as today we owe our sense of the reality of rwanda to peress and nachtwey (pages 274–89). photography cannot stop evil here

and now, but it does limit what it is possible for the future to deny. magnum's work stands for the belief that history exists, that the truth is not relative or perishable, and that photography can contribute evidence in the battle of memory against forgetting. not everyone has this faith. if you think that no one will remember, that the truth will never be sorted out from the lies, and that every pit will eventually be covered over with oblivion, then you should not be taking photographs for magnum.

when the photographers who were to create magnum came home from the wars in 1945, they were, in cartier-bresson's words, 'completely lost'. the world was in ruins: they were war photographers struggling to adjust to the uncertainties of a long peace and the emerging political divides of the cold war. their war work had given distinction to photography, but they were not certain that the medium could preserve its freedom in peacetime. they wanted independence from the picture editors; they wanted control of their negatives and ability to generate the income that would allow them the freedom to choose their own assignments. these were the practical imperatives which led capa, seymour, cartier-bresson and rodger to found the agency over lunch in new york in 1947. they did not put out an aesthetic or ethical manifesto: they did not talk about politics: all of it was simply in the pictures. this laconic insistence that pictures must do the talking was not modest: it made an important claim about the medium's essential dignity. it was not just the filler between the advertisements; it was not just the illustration of a text. the pictures had their own status, their own right to exist, to teach, to speak, to be observed in their own terms. as the first of the agencies to seek to give photographers control over their own work, magnum did as much as any institution to get photography taken seriously.

as magnum turns fifty, we should remember what else is also turning fifty: the universal declaration of human rights and the genocide convention, both enacted in 1948, and the geneva conventions on the laws of war signed in august 1949. these documents were the work of a liberal internationalist moral imagination, trying to rebuild the self-belief of victors who had seen auschwitz and hiroshima. magnum belongs to that moment of renewal. its very first joint project as an agency was a

magazine essay whose working title was 'people are people the world over'. magnum's task was providing the iconography of a liberal moral universalism which was trying to believe in itself again. linked to this faith was a commitment to the moral power of documentation. the photographers believed that horror might be stopped if we actually took the trouble to see what it really was. this was not a pacifist or abolitionist impulse so much as simple anger at the illusions which people in safety entertain about zones of danger. magnum's photography – whether in the old tradition or the new – is part of a determined twentieth-century effort to deny war its rhetoric of glory and to stop the sentimentalization of suffering. the magnum aesthetic – which became an ethic – was to show us what was real, so that we would talk less nonsense, so that our words and feeling would be more adequate



ernst haas, homecoming of prisoners of war, vienna, 1947

to reality. an example: chim seymour's famous picture of the survivor of a concentration camp (this page), a little girl, still emaciated, standing at a blackboard covered with the crazed circles which she has just chalked to describe her world. it is an image which, precisely, does not say it all. the jagged lines on the blackboard and her occluded gaze seem to hint that the inner world of a survivor will remain unreachable to the most compassionate observer.

and then that founding moment of the late 1940s was gone. capa's work was an attack on the dubious glamour of war, but he himself proved unable to live without it. so in 1954 he went to vietnam. on patrol with the french in a rice field, he stepped on a mine and died with his final pictures in his camera. the man who did more than anyone to create the iconography of the last great european conflict died creating the iconography of the wars of the future: the jungle wars, the counter-insurgency wars of the vietnam era and beyond.

within days of capa's death, werner bischof died in peru and two years later chim seymour died at sues. in this moment of crisis and doubt, magnum's liberal humanist ethics also came under attack. in 1954, the photographer edward steichen assembled 'the family of man' exhibition at the museum of modern art in new york. the agency contributed more images than any other group of photographers and its theme – that human beings belonged to a single family – did encapsulate magnum's core beliefs. the hydrogen bomb, just then tested by both america and russia, gave frantic urgency to this affirmation of human universality. the catalogue had uplifting quotations from the bible, shakespeare and the homilies of many cultures, and the exhibit's last image was gene smith's image of two children, hand in hand, walking upward along a path towards a light-filled funnel of the forest. 'the family of man' is the visual iconography of the universal declaration of human rights: beneath difference, identity; beneath differences of status and condition, a fundamental equality.

when the exhibit – seen around the world – went to paris, the french literary critic and essayist, roland barthes, then associated with the communist party, wrote a famously sarcastic review, attacking the exhibit for resting 'on a very old mystification which always consists in placing nature at the bottom of history'. the



david (chim) seymour. tereza at orphanage. poland. 1948

illusion was to believe that human unity is more important than difference, that prejudice, class power and colonial oppression pale before our common humanity. but this photographic celebration of human universality, barthes went on to say, 'tells us, literally, nothing'. worse, it hides the enduring historical injustice of the world. looking back now, it is less obvious that 'the family of man' was the apologia for liberal capitalist complacency that barthes took it to be. in fact, it could be criticized for being more naïvely indulgent about communism than capitalism. after quoting from thomas jefferson – 'i know no safe depository of the ultimate powers of society but the people themselves' – it went on to display photos of people speaking out or going to the ballot box in south africa, iran, france, japan, china, turkey – as if these were all the same sort of jeffersonian democracy. a similar exercise in moral

w. eugene smith. civil guard. village of deleitosa. spain. 1951



abstraction is observable in marc riboud's photography of china in the 1950s. riboud celebrated the heroic endurance of the chinese people and the beauty of their landscape, at exactly the moment when millions of them were dying of famine in the odious politics of the great leap forward. the issue is not whether a photographer should be blamed for failing to see what only became evident afterwards, but rather that when we view these photographs, forty years later, their abstract humanist beauty draws us into an act of political and historical amnesia. so the question raised by barthes' critique remains valid, even if his marxist ironies now ring hollow. the truth is that photography does compress complex moments of suffering and injustice – which have long and ambiguous histories – into necessarily simplified and abstracted visual icons.

we always think photography tells us more than it does. we always think we understand more than we do when we look at a photograph. the reality is that we do not know the people in the photographs; the photographers themselves often do not even know the names of the people whose suffering or elation or terror they are recording. luc delahaye speaks of the 'restraint that is only possible by the photographer eschewing any relation with the subject'. magnum's liberal humanism may appear warm and sentimental: on closer examination, its photographers turn a cold eye on the world.

magnum photography documents the distance between strangers, between the scream being uttered and going unheard, between the hand reaching out for help and failing to receive any. thanks to magnum images, the moral distance between zones of safety and zones of danger has been rendered visible in the past fifty years. we cannot pretend we do not know what is going on in rwanda, kosovo, bosnia. thanks to photography, we can also document our never-ending failure to respond adequately or in time. gilles peress' work seems inspired by cold fury: documenting a war in bosnia and a genocide in rwanda which nobody did anything to stop until it was too late.

because of these images, our moral imagination is extended to situations we have never been in ourselves. we know what corpses look like; what bullets do to bodies; what blood looks like when it sprays across the snow; how it must feel to die, untended and alone. if anything, the tradition has become more graphic, more explicit with time, deliberately exploring the fine line that separates detachment from voyeurism. magnum's photographers are sometimes criticized for 'aestheticizing' violence, for making killing seem beautiful. but that is surely their job: to make terror beautiful so that it will be unforgettable; so that it will burn into people's memories; so that they will do something to stop it, if they can. and if they cannot, to at least understand what terror means. thanks to these photographers, we cannot claim that we were deceived; we cannot claim that we did not know. ignorance is no longer a plausible alibi in a world made transparent by imagery. if we, the audience for these pictures, have not done what we should with our knowledge, if we have not acted as we might have done and made our leaders act as they should, we cannot blame our messengers.

with the coming of television in the 1950s and 1960s, photography at first seemed to cede its place as a moral mediator. certainly the new medium represented the kind of challenge to photojournalism that photography had posed to painting in the 1860s. in the process, photography lost its remaining hold on narrative story-telling, the photo-essay, which had been a staple of 'life', 'picture post', 'paris match' and 'vu', and a central part of magnum output now seemed redundant beside the story-telling power of television documentary and news. capa's insight had been

that photography which loses sight of documentation risks becoming mannerism, while photography which loses the ambitions of art loses the possibility of becoming unforgettable. by the 1960s, the documentation of war and disaster was passing increasingly into the hands of associated press, reuters and agence france presse. these agency photographers were often courageous and competent, but the magnum ideal had been higher: to raise documentation to the level of art, the market for magnum's kind of intensely personal and intensely seen war photography was now shrinking. magnum photography might have resigned itself to a mannerist future: either as formalist art or as ironic advertising. yet this did not happen. despite the coming of television, and the demise of the photo-weeklies, photography retained its ability to define the essential iconography of key historical experiences. none of the

television or cinema images of prague in 1968 have the same power as the stills taken by the young czech photographer, josef koudelka. his images seem inexhaustible in their capacity to disclose new information because, unlike film, they freeze experience as memory does and hold up time itself to examination. television seems to tell us everything we need to know. it drains reality of mystery by suggesting that what we see is all there is. good photography restores the mystery of the world by stopping time so that we can both see and reflect upon what is there. hence the unending strangeness of photography: that it both documents the world, establishes what is essentially there, while at the same time showing to us what we cannot see with our eyes alone. so if photography has a redeeming or cleansing effect on our vision, it is because it seems to restore both the reality of the world and its essential elusiveness.



werner bischof. press photographers covering the war. korea. 1951

hiroschi hamaya. woman planting rice. toyama, japan. 1955



if this intention of the magnum founders remains as relevant as ever, it is becoming more difficult to achieve. the founders of magnum could never have imagined how supersaturated with images our world has become in the past fifty years. so that a magnum photographer today is, of necessity, a visual guerrilla, creating images which invite us to be still, to pause, to think again, to question the terms of a three-minute culture which consumes visual images like fast food. yet if all these aesthetic intentions in the magnum tradition have survived, the fate of its moral vision, its liberal idealism, is less certain. its ethics was a creature of its time, of the liberal internationalism of the 1940s and the beginning of the cold war.

its politics were popular, democratic and liberal. in the 1950s and 1960s, its photographers – eve arnold, burt glinn, constantine manos, wayne miller – documented the american civil-rights struggle, and bruce davidson's patiently devoted study of a block of harlem brought the same moral and emotional attention to the photography of the poor as had once been lavished on the portrait photography of the rich. from the early 1960s and 1970s, magnum's moral energies were directed to documenting first the misadventures and crimes of american imperialism, from philip jones griffiths' images of vietnam to susan meiselas' work in nicaragua and el salvador, to the imperial blunders of the russians in afghanistan. in 1989, when the berlin wall came down, james nachtwey was there to document the hands tearing down the barbed wire (pages 64–5), and leonard freed was in bucharest to depict the bloody street battles as romania threw off the yoke of the ceausescu dictatorship and its hated secret police (pages 66–9). in 1991, stuart franklin took the image of the young chinese man standing in front of the line of tanks (page 343). these images, together with the ones which nachtwey took in south africa after mandela's return, derived their power from a tacit narrative of liberation. after 1989, we all thought that we were walking on the road to freedom. the age of empire was over. the era of self-determination had dawned. history was not over – but one of its oldest, most costly and most sterile battles, between communism and capitalism, certainly was. in this euphoric setting, photography, to the degree that it ever serves any cause, could document the strange, sometimes violent but essentially hopeful dawn of freedom. we did not know that this moment of hope would prove to be exceedingly short – from the summer and autumn of 1989 to the summer of 1991, when the violent disintegration of yugoslavia began.

a much darker era dawned between september and november 1991 with the siege of vukovar, the old episcopal town in croatia, pounded to rubble by serbian artillery in the attempt to prevent croatian independence. after that, in the summer of 1992, came the ethnic cleansing of bosnia, as serbian paramilitaries sought to destroy the bosnian state and create a serbian state in its place. from 1992 through 1995, magnum photographers – chris steele-perkins, james nachtwey, gilles peress, luc delahaye, raymond depardon – documented the sarajevo siege, as serbian artillery on the hills above sought to destroy a european city and western europe watched, and listened, and saw the unforgettable images, and did precisely nothing. the story of

freedom had given way to a story of ethnic cleansing and civil war. magnum's photographers became the artists of this anarchy, documenting the slow stain of savagery as it spread. delahaye shows us the moment in a sarajevo hospital when a brother loses a brother (pages 190-1): a doctor slumps in a chair, staring helplessly at his hands, another man buries his head on the windowsill, and through the slanting light death stands invisible but palpable in the haunted space between the crushed human figures. it is a pietà for our inglorious time. as the wars for the dismemberment of yugoslavia went on, the wars for the dismemberment of central africa got underway. in many cases, photographers who had been following south africa's first free elections went straight from covering a story of freedom to rwanda, to cover a story of inconceivable butchery, all on the same continent, within two hours'

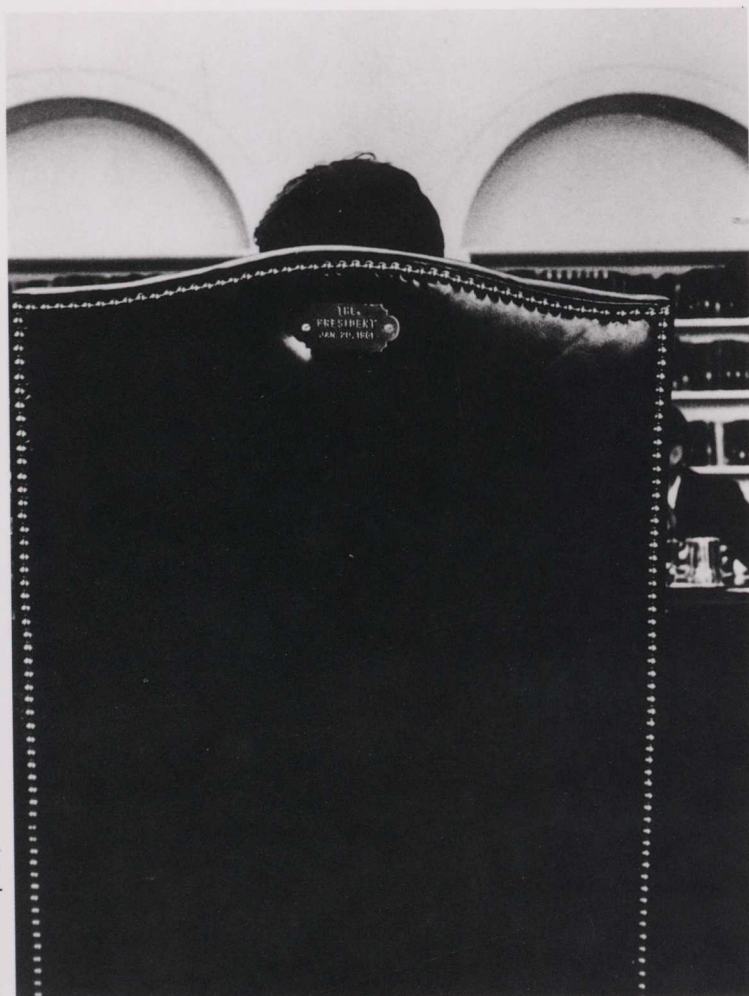
flying time. as in bosnia, so in rwanda: documentary photography reached a moment of utter despair which seemed to mock magnum's guiding premise. magnum photography existed to eradicate the alibi of ignorance. now that ignorance had been swept away everyone could see what genocide looked like in rwanda and in bosnia, and nothing happened.

and now kosovo, the last act in the forcible dismemberment of yugoslavia by a serbian regime which has steadfastly resisted all claims to self-determination except those of serbs. kosovo presents us with another fait accompli: the most extensive deportation of a people since the end of world war II. as the millennium approaches, the story of freedom has given way to a much older story, one which



marilyn silverstone. lady 'vizzy'. durbar hall of maharaja's palace, benares, india. 1959

cornell capa. president john f. kennedy in the oval office, washington, dc. 1961



has no certain ending – the story of the battle between civilization and barbarism. magnum knows which side it is on, but it is questioning its own *raison d'être*. commitment is disparaged; idealism seems innocent, naïve or self-promoting, and ironic detachment seems a much safer bet than conviction. liberal humanism is easily dismissed as a western imperialist gaze, passing off as universal what is in fact only european. the magnum tradition of documenting african or asian or south balkan violence can easily seem like a sophisticated form of post-imperial voyeurism. so now there might be few magnum photographers who would lay claim to the ideal of trying to show that human beings are the same underneath the skin. the successors – represented in this book – seem intent chiefly to represent the

modern world in all its fragmented, perplexed confusion. the world is in pieces: there are no cold-war mastodons left to oppose; no liberal or any other certainties to align oneself with; so be it, these image-makers seem to be saying. let us go out and see the world. these photographers do not want to affirm, just look; do not want to speak out, just observe; do not want to convince or persuade, just show. the purpose of photography is not political or moral or anything else: the purpose of photography is photography. end of story.

magnum was born before television, before video, before the electronic deluge, the moronic inferno. the heirs of the tradition now work within a visual field dominated by the digitized video image. sometimes the stills photographer has to work against that visual field, salvaging something still and permanent from the ceaseless data stream. sometimes, the stills photographer works with the new aesthetics made possible by the new media. the work by martin parr, lise sarfati, constantine manos, harry gruyaert and susan meiselas takes for granted the new aesthetics of a video world: the off-centre framing, the graininess, the strange, eccentric juxtaposition of images, the deliberate loss of context; the strange, degraded colours. again, television does not stop to pause over strangeness and incongruity, so instead of being crowded out, stills photographers often have whole fields of our strange new visual world all to themselves. what television or documentary cameraman would have paused over the strange scene which harry gruyaert captured in alexandria (pages 230–1): the car wrapped in its shroud, the gateway half raised, dawn on the rise and what appears to be a set of gigantic false teeth the size of a bed on the pavement?

since the end of the cold war, the collective focus of magnum, to the degree that it has one, has been on the incongruities thrown up by globalization. these juxtapositions and oddities are the visual essence of uneven development in globalization: how new and old, modern, post-modern and ancient co-exist in the same frame; how, in marc riboud's photographs of the islamic world (pages 220–3), women in the traditional chodor make their way past truncated market dummies standing in the street; how chodor and jeans sit side by side on the steps of an ancient building.

in japan, chris steele-perkins captures the traditional bonsai garden, stuck next to a bright coke machine (pages 396–7); in athens, martin parr finds the tourists posing in front of the parthenon, like astronauts in front of some lunar ruin (page 46). in afghanistan, steve mccurry finds a fighter lying back on a weirdly incongruous sofa standing outside a building shredded back to its steel reinforcing rods by the artillery of the mujaheddin (page 12). the history we have lived in the past decade is here, so that looking at the images the blur of time, the slur of forgetting, is arrested, and we live it again: the armageddon of the gulf war; the carbonized bodies on the basra road; the

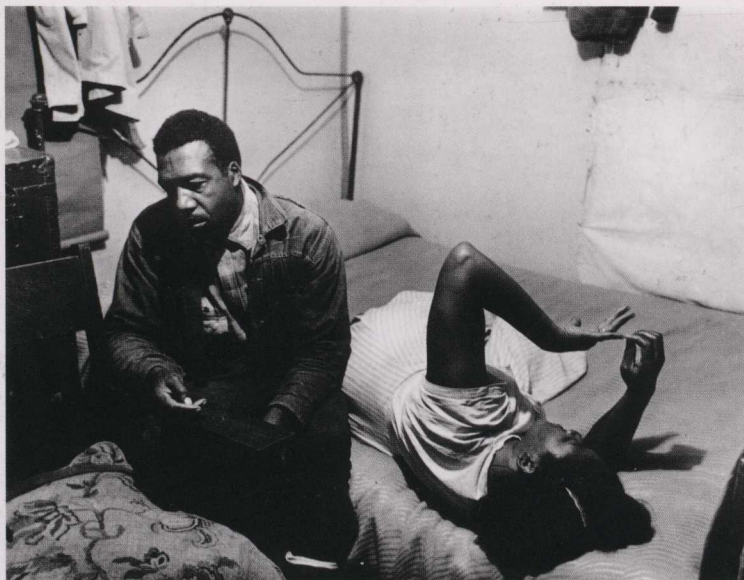
plo mother mourning her dead son; the faces of the israeli soldiers and what the work of repression has done to them; the kurds at the turkish border in 1991, begging to be fed; the man in front of the tank in tiananmen square; the ugandan child with her hands cut off; the bodies piled high by the bulldozers in goma. it is all here, like the fragments of some gigantic puzzle which we collect in the hope that one day we might be able to assemble it into a discernible pattern. but the pattern escapes us now; it is too close. the photographers, like us, are too close to know what it means, but the act of taking the pictures implies, even in the most forlorn or hopeless context, that one day the shape of our fragmented time will be discernible and that these images will disclose some of the secrets of what we have lived through.

and in some of these images we have a vision of the future. in koudelka's strange image of the bound statue of lenin on the barge, heading out into a grey delta towards the ocean (pages 4–5), we seem to be seeing the image of communism itself passing out of the present into the realm of the styx. in abbas' photo of abbas' kiarostami trying to peer through a riddled iron gate, stuck in the middle of nowhere (page 13), we seem to have a metaphor for all our comic incapacity to glimpse the world about to unfold. the photos of erich hartmann of the concentration camps (pages 178–81) bring us back to magnum's beginnings, to the devastated stillness which followed the end of world war II, as the european imagination began to struggle with the full dimensions of the destruction it had brought upon itself. in the 1990s, hartmann returned to the camps – now museum sites – to record his discovery that the struggle to make sense of them never ends. as the historical distance grows, the camps seem less and less real; and it requires more and more imagination to encompass their sheer enormity. hartmann's photographs, in their unearthly beauty, capture the fact of the holocaust as it shimmers into disappearance. the boot-store might – in 1945 – have been documented simply as a boot-store. now, fifty years later, we see the boots across the misty, gauzy and imprecise shimmer of a window's reflection, the very image of our own struggle to see, to apprehend, to hold onto the terrible reality implied by these nameless piles of footwear. at its best, the work in this collection has the capacity to incite a much wider range of meaning than the subject it documents. in koudelka's study of the black triangle (pages 94–101) – the ecologically devastated zone of northern bohemia – the work is at the service of a passionate



sergio larrain. london. 1959

wayne miller. usa. 1955



conviction, which would be recognizable to the magnum founders, that we must see what we have done to the earth in order to turn back before it is too late. in koudelka's own words, 'it is entirely up to us whether this will be a habitable countryside, whether we are going to leave behind a hideous wilderness with uprooted people.' beyond this photographer's cry at the devastation of his own homeland, these images of dark roads leading nowhere, this forest of signs pointing this way and that, these bleak lunar landscapes seem to imply something larger. they may be foreboding images of a future which it has become too late to avoid.

there is no reason to suppose that there will be another anniversary of magnum, no reason to suppose that the co-operative will survive the volcanic conflicts of temperaments and ideals which have exploded over the years; no reason to suppose that it will not lose its history and become just another agency feeding the awesome hunger of the modern media machine. traditions do not come with guarantees. they come and they go, and sometimes it is better that they should disappear. but the new generation seem to have understood the paradox that a great tradition forbids imitation and commands dissent from those who would wish to stay true to its essential vision. magnum probably owes its survival, as a loose coalition of intensely individual image-makers, to its capacity to keep itself open to the new and

the unexpected. yet the fact that photographers who were not even born when the agency was founded still want to associate themselves with everything it signifies is a testament to its enduring vitality. a great tradition is alive – because it is being re-invented.

michael ignatieff



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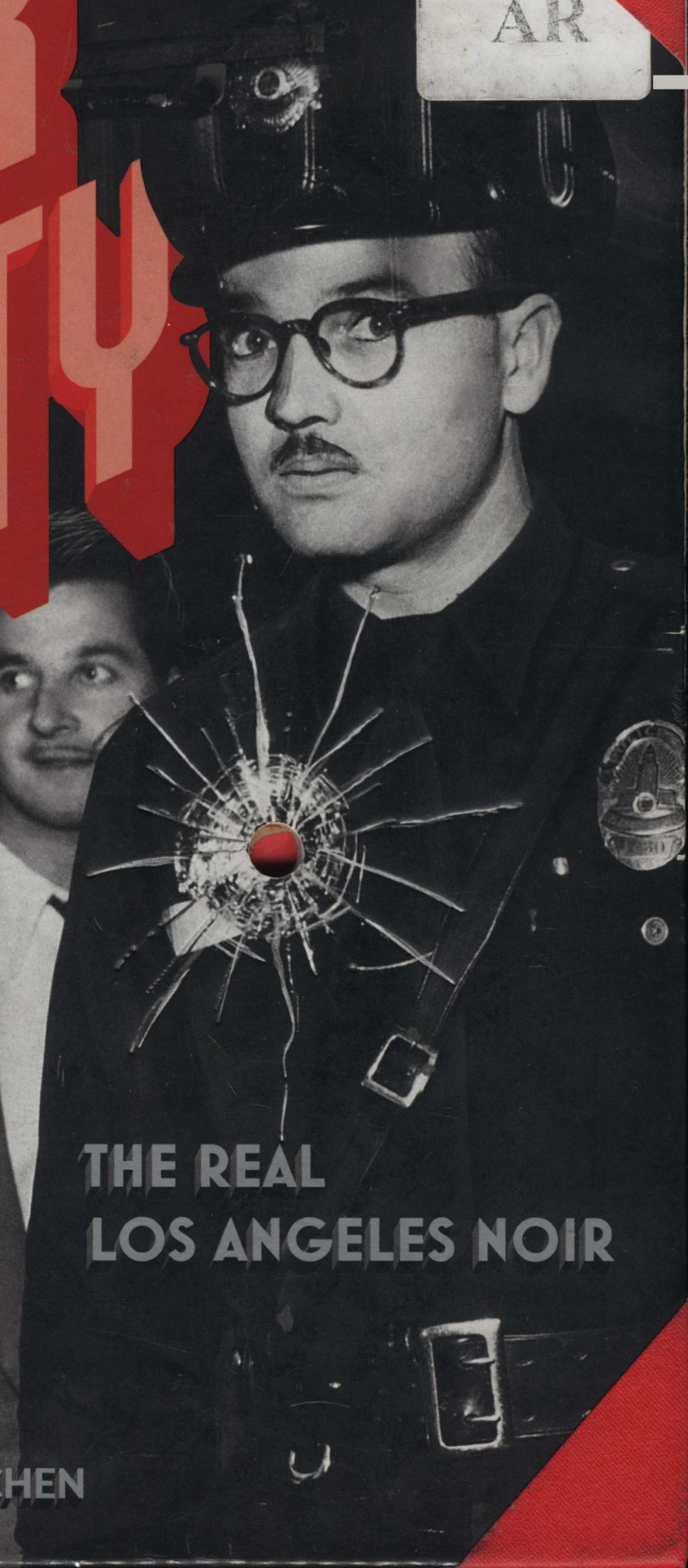
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TASCHEN

JIM HEIM

AR

DARK CITY



THE REAL
LOS ANGELES NOIR

TASCHEN



DARK CITY — JIM HEIMANN

INTRODUCTION

JIM HEIMANN

LOS ANGELES. Its name alone has stirred visions of romance and adventure: Hollywood, sunshine, beaches, and endless rows of orange trees. This glowing and glossy image that was offered to the world by city boosters and the chamber of commerce was produced in an endless cycle, the slick promotional propaganda spewing forth for over a century. Meanwhile, just below the surface of the public relations campaign lurked another side of the City of Angels. The underbelly of Los Angeles was festering like oranges rotting in the perpetual sun.

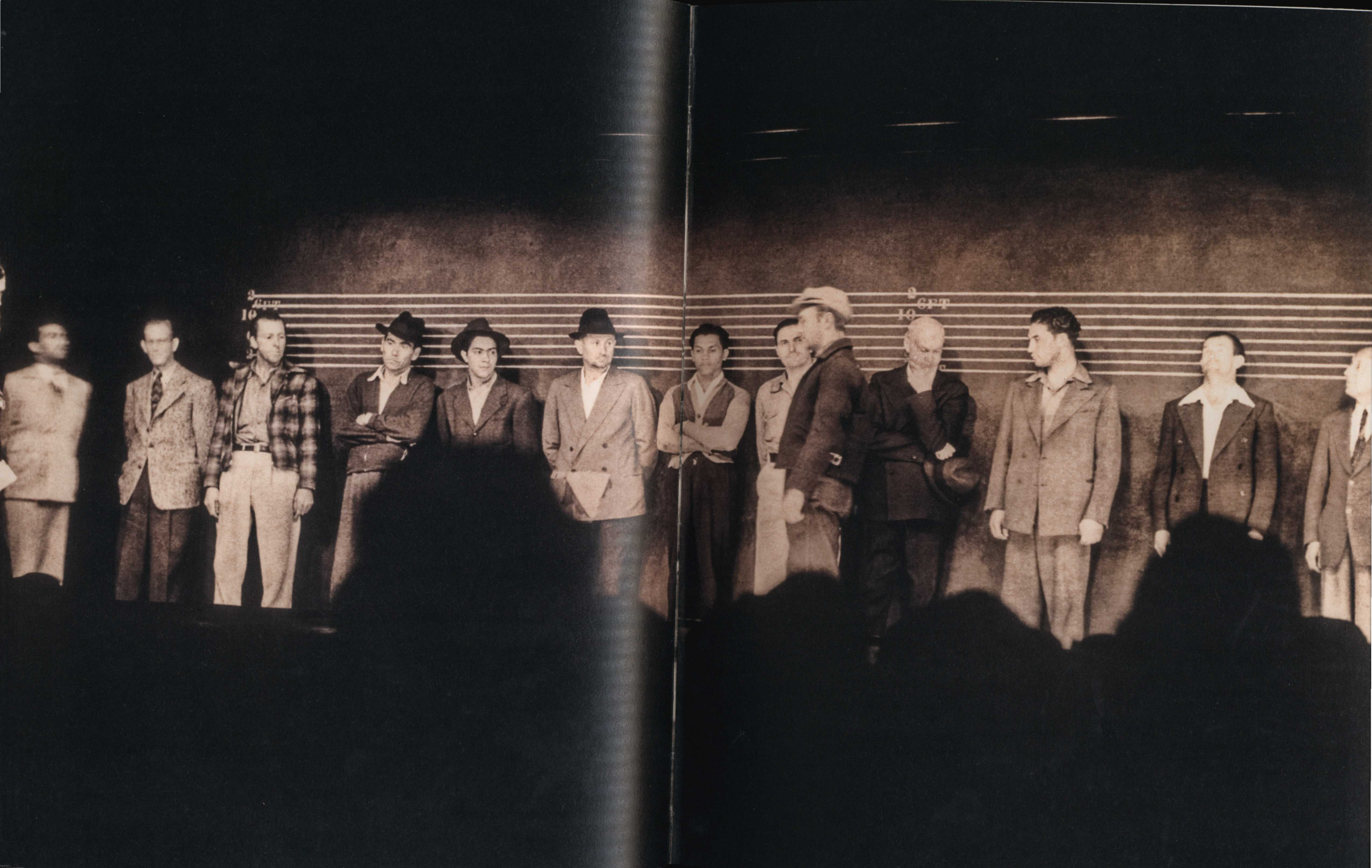
Primary to the city's image were its commercial and newspaper photographers, who, in the years that framed its intense development, captured a precise portrait of a city in the process of inventing itself. Photographs from the 1920s through the '50s show a changing landscape of altered streets, leveled hills, and buildings constructed and then eliminated to accommodate even more change. The photos also detail the nightclubs and bars, the buried bodies, the lifeless forms on coroners' slabs, Hollywood celebrities, politicians, boulevard degenerates, and self-proclaimed saviors of the soul. These images expose both the bright and the dark sides of a city absorbed in the present and looking toward the future. They document a city in constant change, rapidly evolving from adobe squalor to "the Wonder City of the West."

Photographers could make the town look good and bad. The glamour shots helped bring thousands of new residents to the Southland. Promotional imagery of mountains, sun, and surf promised a better life and unlimited possibilities, but newspaper and tabloid photos showed newcomers that the seductive vision wasn't the

whole story. The flip side of paradise was a different Southland, one where dope rings, petty criminals, sensational murders, ladies of the night, bullet-riddled bodies, and a notoriously corrupt police force flourished. It was the other Los Angeles—a city awash in corruption and sin. The posed and the candid. The good and the bad. A city to aspire to and a city to revile. Both versions were responsible for creating the mythic City of Angels. The photos and stories told of a town on the backside, documented in black and white and furnishing the reality behind the writers' fiction.

The press photographers who created those images were a wide cadre of lensmen who often had inordinate access to crime scenes, morgues, and places few others could enter. Striking up friendships with police personnel, they roamed the streets following leads and sniffing out the next great shot. Many of their names have faded over time, though consummate pros included Perry Fowler, Agness "Aggie" Underwood, and Paul Dorsey, all from the *Los Angeles Herald-Express*, along with Cliff Wesselmann, who worked for the *Hollywood Citizen-News*, and George Watson of the *Los Angeles Times*. Watson, along with his six nephews, created a family business, producing over a million images of the city in its ascendancy.

The Los Angeles Police Department (LAPD) photographers, often the first at the scene of the crime, were a mostly anonymous bunch who did a perfunctory job but often with an experienced and artistic eye. Among the commercial photographers in Los Angeles, the "Dick" Whittington Studio, led by founder Wayne Whittington



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GANGSTERS in HOLLYWOOD

**Lana Turner
and the Mickey Cohen
Mobster**

**The Odessa, Texas,
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25c



WHY IKE BOUNCED VANDENBERG JR.

SEE PAGE 21

Confidential

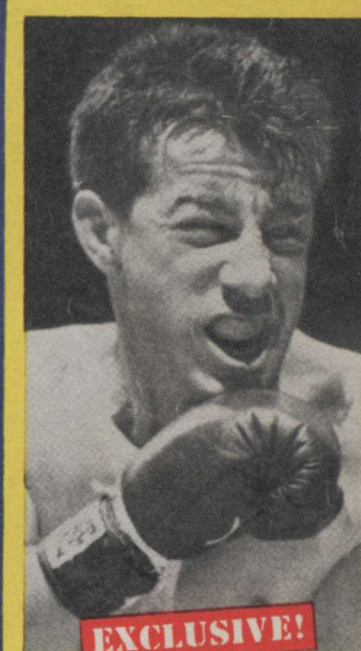
TELLS THE FACTS THE NAMES Nov. 25¢



Memo to Dean Martin:
Better Doublecheck
on Your Ex-wife!



IT WAS A SCANDALOUS WAY TO BEHAVE — EVEN
FOR MARLON BRANDO AND HIS TAN TOOTSIE!



EXCLUSIVE!

His Own Sister Tells
What Rocky Graziano
Forgot to Remember!

That Blonde Sharing
Nick Ray's Pillow Was
MARILYN MONROE!

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